

Access Customer Handbook

Southwest Ohio Regional Transit Authority



Table of Contents

- Section 1:** Introduction
- Section 2:** Eligibility and Certification
- Section 3:** Service Area and Hours
- Section 4:** Access Trip Reservations
- Section 5:** Taking an Access Trip
- Section 6:** Vehicle Operator Responsibilities
- Section 7:** Access Passenger Policies
- Section 8:** Service Suspension Appeal Procedures
- Section 9:** Customer Services Questions, Comments & Complaints
- Section 10:** Glossary
- Section 11:** Contact Information

Please note that Access Policies and Procedures are subject to change. Passengers will be notified of changes through passenger notices and/or other Metro public announcements. Please make sure Access always has the passenger's current address, phone number, and e-mail address (if applicable).

Accessible formats and reasonable modifications are available upon request. An accessible format may be requested by contacting:

Access General Information

Phone: 513-632-7586

Email: accessinfo@go-metro.com

ACCESS 

Section 1: Introduction

ADA PARATRANSIT SERVICE

The Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) is a civil rights law that was passed by Congress in 1990. The law ensures civil rights protection and access to public transit services for qualified persons with disabilities. The ADA established regulations requiring that jurisdictions provide the same public transportation opportunities to people with disabilities as to those without disabilities. To accomplish this the ADA requires that a complementary transit service (called paratransit) be provided to those with disabilities who are unable to use fixed route service either some or all the time (under ADA law 49 CFR Part 37). Access is Metro's paratransit service.

ADA complementary service applies to "standard" or "regular" fixed route bus lines. It does not include commuter bus, feeder service, limited stop routes, express service, flex route service, or bus rapid transit.

The ADA defines a disability, with respect to an individual, as a physical or mental



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impairment that substantially limits one or more major life activities (caring for oneself, performing manual tasks, walking, seeing, hearing, speaking, breathing, learning, and working). The mere presence of a disability does not make a person eligible for Access paratransit service.

In order to receive services, all Access passengers must be certified through the in-person eligibility assessment outlined in this manual. A person is likely to receive some level of paratransit service eligibility if their functional ability to use Metro's accessible fixed route service is impaired due specifically to a disability. All people who are able to use the regular bus service are expected to use the regular bus system when it is reasonable to do so. Specific details on eligibility requirements and how to apply may be found in Section 2 of this manual.

OVERVIEW OF SERVICES

Access is a shared-ride paratransit service providing origin to destination service for eligible passengers seven (7) days a week. "Shared ride" means that multiple passengers may receive service on the same vehicle at the same time. Access uses a mix of vehicle types to provide the best service possible.

Access provides paratransit service to complement SORTA's fixed route bus system (referred to as Metro) with comparable hours,

days, and service area. The Access service area is the area within $\frac{3}{4}$ of a mile from Metro's regular fixed route bus service. The Access service area is not defined by commuter bus, feeder, limited-stop routes, express, flex route, or bus rapid transit.



Fixed route service changes that impact the service area, days of service, or hours of service will directly affect Access' service area, service days, and service hours.

NOTE: *Public school districts are responsible for providing transportation for grade K-12 students during regular school hours and days.*

Access is not equipped to provide medical care during transit. Individuals who require transportation and have a medically unstable condition must obtain medical transportation services from another agency.

Section 2: Eligibility and Certification

WHO IS ELIGIBLE?

Paratransit eligibility is defined by the ADA (49 CFR PART 37.123) and includes three categories:

Category 1: ADA 1

A person who is unable, as a result of a physical or mental impairment (including a vision impairment), and without the assistance of another individual (except the operator of a wheelchair lift or other boarding assistance device) to board, ride, or exit any vehicle independently on the fixed route system that is readily accessible and usable by persons with disabilities.

Category 2: ADA 2

A person who needs the assistance of a wheelchair lift or other boarding assistance device and one is not available on the fixed route service during the time the individual wishes to travel.

Category 3: ADA 3

A person who has a specific impairment-related condition that prevents getting to or leaving a bus stop.

TYPES OF ELIGIBILITY

Access assigns various types of eligibility categories to passengers based on functional abilities. These eligibility categories are outlined within this section. Passengers are required to provide new or additional information related to their mobility any time the passenger's mobility level or disability changes, even if it is not yet time to recertify for service. Passengers certified for Access will be granted eligibility for service up to five (5) years, depending on the type of eligibility granted.

Unconditional Eligibility

Individuals may qualify as unconditionally eligible if they are unable to access or ride any aspect of the fixed route system. Individuals who meet the ADA criteria for full unconditional paratransit service eligibility may schedule rides from any origin to any destination within the ADA service area during service hours comparable to fixed route service. Unconditional eligibility will be granted for up to five (5) years.

Unconditionally eligible passengers will be required to recertify through the standard in-person eligibility process after their eligibility period ends. Passengers who have a disability or condition which



permanently prevents them from ever using the fixed route system at any point in the future and have already attended an in-person interview at least once may be allowed to bypass the standard eligibility recertification process. These qualifying passengers will be notified that they are not required to undergo an in-person interview to recertify for service and will only be contacted to update their information periodically.

Conditional Eligibility

Some applicants are able to use the fixed route system at least some of the time under certain conditions. Conditionally eligible passengers include persons who are eligible for paratransit only when certain conditions exist including, but not limited to: seasonal (cold, heat, dark, light, snow), pathway (uneven, curb cuts, incline, inaccessible bus stop, complex traffic, distance), navigational, or other applicable conditions. Accommodation for conditionally eligible passengers may also include transportation from an inaccessible origin or destination to an accessible fixed route.



Conditionally eligible passengers are only authorized to use Access when the conditions are present. An example would be when a person designated “Extreme heat only” needs to ride in the middle



of a hot summer day can ride Access but on a cool fall day they would be required to ride the regular fixed route bus.

The simple rule to remember if a passenger is determined conditionally eligible is:

If I am able to take the trip on the regular fixed route bus, then I must take my trip on the fixed route bus.

A functional assessment may be used to determine the conditions under which a person is eligible for paratransit service. The details of these travel conditions will be included in the eligibility decision letter the applicant receives by mail.

Temporary Eligibility

Passengers who have temporary disabilities or conditions which prevent them from accessing fixed route service may qualify for temporary eligibility. Passengers will be eligible to receive services for a length of time determined by a qualified transportation professional, with information provided to them through eligibility documentation. The length of time eligibility is granted will be based on the unique needs of the passenger. Access will notify passengers at least 45 days before the temporary eligibility expires, if the eligibility period they have been granted exceeds this time frame.

If the temporary situation lasts longer than originally anticipated, the individual may be required to repeat the verification process and submit a new application. Temporary eligibility cannot exceed 18 months.



Eligibility for Children ages 5 and under

Children five (5) years of age and younger will be considered for Paratransit eligibility based on the functional ability of both the accompanying adult and child (as a team) to use fixed route bus service. When an eligible child is traveling with an adult (who is serving as a Personal Care Attendant), a fare must be paid for the child and the adult attendant rides free.

Out-of-Town Visitors with Disabilities

Visitors to the Metro service area who have been certified as eligible for paratransit services in their hometown, may be eligible to receive temporary paratransit services from Access. This also applies to Access passengers who wish to travel to other cities that offer their own paratransit services. The temporary period is limited to 21 days of paratransit service.



Visitors with disabilities should contact the Eligibility office at (513) 632-7586 as far in advance as possible to receive service. Visitors must provide current ADA eligibility for Paratransit service from the city, region, or jurisdiction in which they reside or documentation of place of residence and nature of their disability. Visitors who require more than 21 days of service in the calendar year will be required to apply for and complete the full Access eligibility process.

LEVELS OF SERVICE

Access will provide origin to destination services using two service levels: curb-to-curb and door-to-door. Access will work with each passenger during the eligibility and recertification processes to determine what level of service is most appropriate. This determination is based on a person's functional abilities and any environmental constraints or conditions related to the passenger's disability.

Curb-to-Curb Service

Passengers are required to meet the vehicle at the pick-up location. The vehicle operator will assist the passenger on and off the vehicle. The curb-to-curb service is the most appropriate level of service for Access passengers who do not require assistance outside of the vehicle.

Some locations may be coded curb-to-curb for all passengers, due to certain conditions where the Access operator is unable to safely provide door-to-door service.

Passengers may still wait inside their home or building for the vehicle to arrive. However, once the vehicle arrives, the passenger will have five (5) minutes to leave the area where they were waiting, travel to the waiting vehicle, and board. It is recommended that passengers wait in a location where they or their companion/assistant can clearly identify the vehicle when it arrives.



A higher level of service (door-to-door) is available when requested at the time of the reservation or at the time of the drop off for any passenger who was certified for a lower assistance level during the eligibility process. The higher level of service is not guaranteed and will only be provided if that service does not pose a safety risk to other passengers, Metro property, or the vehicle operator as defined under the Service Level Exceptions section below.



Door-to-Door Service

Passengers designated as door-to-door will receive assistance from an Access operator beginning from the departure point of the passenger's location of origin and ending at the entrance point of the passenger's destination. Access vehicle operators are required to escort the passenger between the vehicle and the door at both origin and destination for all trips.

Service Level Exceptions

Vehicle operators shall not provide service that exceeds curb-to-curb service if the vehicle operator is required to:

- Leave the vehicle for lengthy periods of time.
- Lose sight of the vehicle.
- Take actions that would be clearly unsafe (i.e., back a vehicle more than a car length, enter a narrow drive, etc.).
- Leave other passengers unattended.
- Vehicle operators are never permitted to enter a passenger's residence.

Passengers who require a higher level of service than curb-to-curb, but for whom service cannot be provided at their origin or destination due to any of the conditions listed, will need to work with Access to identify alternative options that will ensure safety for passengers and vehicle operators.

APPLICATION FOR PARATRANSIT SERVICE

Passengers who meet ADA criteria for paratransit service eligibility and wish to apply for Access may request an application in the accessible format of their choice by contacting Access in one of the following ways:

- **Phone:** (513) 632-7586
- **Mail:** Accessible Services, 1801 Transpark Drive, Cincinnati, OH 45229

The Access Application has two sections:

Applicant Request for Paratransit Service

The applicant or their designated representative must provide contact information such as a current home address, phone number, emergency contact, e-mail, etc. The applicant or their designated representative will also provide information related to the applicant's functional abilities.

IN-PERSON ELIGIBILITY REVIEW

All applicants for Access' ADA paratransit service must come into the Silverton Eligibility facility at least once for an in-person eligibility assessment. The *ADA Transportation Application* must be completed before calling to schedule an eligibility review. It is essential that applicants bring all completed application documents

to the review appointment. Applicants are encouraged to bring any additional documentation that may assist the Eligibility Team in getting a more complete understanding of each applicant's specific functional abilities.

Reviews may be scheduled during regular business hours by contacting Access' Eligibility Team at (513) 632-7586.

Access will, upon request, provide free transportation to and from the in-person interview so long as the origin/destination addresses are within the ADA service area. If this assistance is needed, the applicant should notify the Eligibility Team when scheduling an appointment.



Eligibility interviews may take up to two (2) hours to complete. Applicants are encouraged to plan accordingly.

In some cases, the application and interview do not clearly reflect how an applicant's disability affects their functional

ability to ride (board/de-board/navigate) fixed route services. All applicants must participate in the eligibility assessment which

includes an in-person interview and a functional assessment immediately following the in-person interview. A functional assessment is a simple process used to determine what transit-specific tasks an applicant can or cannot complete.

Access considers an application submitted in full upon completion of the in-person interview and functional assessment, and when all required forms and documents have been received and filled out completely. The applicant will be notified of the eligibility decision in writing within 21 calendar days of the Eligibility Assessment.

Any applicant who does not receive notification from Access within 21 calendar days will receive “presumptive eligibility” automatically





beginning on the 22nd day after the applicant has completed the Access eligibility assessment process in full. This presumptive eligibility will be in effect until an official notification of the decision from Metro has been sent to the applicant.

Eligibility assessments are scheduled in the order in which the requests are received. Access does not assign a higher priority to any applicant over another.

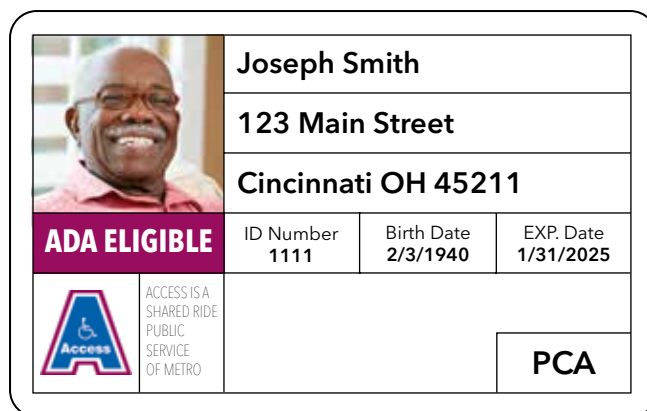
To check on the status of an application, please contact the Access Eligibility Department at (513) 632-7586. A limited number of Access in-person eligibility review appointments are available each day. If the applicant will be unable to make the appointment, please cancel prior to 4:00 PM the day before. This allows other applicants the chance to use the appointment time slot. Applicants that no-show or cancel after 4:00 PM the day before an in-person eligibility review appointment may have a no-show applied to their record (as defined in this guide). In the event you have a no-show, this will become part of your record should you be found eligible for any level of Access service. Applicants who do not become eligible for Access service will not be penalized for a no-show or a late cancel.

ELIGIBILITY DETERMINATION

Approved Eligibility

If the application for service is approved, Access will send a notification letter and welcome packet in an accessible format within 21 calendar days. The welcome packet will provide an overview of the service and include:

- An Access picture ID card.
- Information about other Metro services.
- Information about the date range of service eligibility.
- Explanation about the type of eligibility for which the applicant qualifies.
- Explanation of the service level for which the applicant has been approved.
- Any other additional information requested by the applicant during the eligibility review and orientation process.



Denied Eligibility

If an application for service is denied, Access will send a letter to the applicant within 21 calendar days that lists the specific reason(s) for the denial. The letter will tell the applicant how to proceed if



they wish to appeal the decision or to clarify any information that might have caused an erroneous denial.

Appeal of Eligibility Determination

An appeals process is available for any applicant who would like to dispute an eligibility determination.

An applicant may file an eligibility appeal of a denial or status change within 60 calendar days of the date of that denial or eligibility status change by contacting the Eligibility Department. This may be done by mail, e-mail, fax, or phone call. All passengers appealing their eligibility determination who have NOT completed a full functional assessment during their initial interview will be required to complete a full functional assessment before the appeals committee meeting.

Access' eligibility appeals committee is comprised of persons not involved in any part of the eligibility decision. An observer to the process is allowed if the applicant agrees. New passengers applying for paratransit service will not receive services during the appeals process unless it is determined that a decision was not rendered in 21 calendar days. If the eligibility process determines a different eligibility status for a passenger who was previously approved for paratransit, the passenger will retain his or her current level of service while awaiting the appeals committee's decision.



An Eligibility Department staff member and functional assessor may attend the appeal. Their role is to provide information at the appeal but NOT to vote on the final Appeal Committee determination. Appeals will be held at an accessible Metro facility or a passenger may request an accommodation to conduct the hearing virtually. The applicant is strongly encouraged to bring forth additional information for the appeals committee to consider if any is available. The applicant also can bring an advocate to the hearing to assist in the process.

The appeals committee shall render a decision to the appellant within 30 calendar days after the completion of the appeals process. The decision will be available to the applicant in an accessible format as needed. Should the appeals committee fail to render a decision within 30 days of the completion of the appeals process, Access will continue to provide the current level of paratransit service to the recertification applicant and new applicants will receive unconditional presumptive eligibility. Presumptive or continuing eligibility will remain in place until the eligibility appeals committee has notified the applicant of the decision. The decision of the appeals committee is final.

RECERTIFICATION OF ELIGIBILITY

Passengers are required to recertify their Access eligibility periodically, depending on the type of eligibility granted. Most passengers will be required to come back to Access to participate in the in-person eligibility review upon the expiration of eligibility. If a passenger's disability or mobility improves to the point where Paratransit is no longer needed before recertification, they must notify Access.

An Access eligibility recertification packet will be mailed to customers between 45 and 60 days before their eligibility expires.





Passengers should call Access to schedule their assessment appointment at least 21 calendar days in advance of their eligibility expiration date to avoid an interruption of service. Passengers who do not complete the recertification process before their eligibility expires may have their service suspended until an eligibility determination is made. Passengers who choose not to recertify at the time their service expires may still choose to re-apply for the service at any time in the future.

To ensure compliance with federal guidelines, Access reserves the right to review eligibility on an as-needed basis for registered Access passengers. This is needed to ensure that registered passengers continue to meet eligibility criteria and to determine if or how the passenger's transportation needs have changed.

Section 3: Service Area and Hours

SERVICE AREA

ADA Paratransit Service

Access provides Paratransit transportation services within the ADA paratransit service area. The trip origin and trip destination must be within a $\frac{3}{4}$ mile corridor surrounding regular fixed route service. The regular fixed route service area excludes express, flyer, dial-a-ride, flex routes, bus rapid transit, commuter rail and limited-service routes. Please keep in mind that changes to fixed

route service may directly affect the service area, service days, and service hours of Access service.

OPERATIONAL HOURS

Access Transportation Service

ADA Paratransit service is only provided during hours and days in which the fixed route bus service is provided.

Regular Business Office Hours

<u>Days:</u>	<u>Hours:</u>
Monday-Friday	8:30 a.m. - 5 p.m.

Customer Care Center Hours

<u>Days:</u>	<u>Hours:</u>
Monday-Friday	6:30 a.m. - 6 p.m.
Saturday/Sunday/Holiday	8 a.m. - 5 p.m.

HOLIDAY SERVICE

Access provides paratransit service every day of the year. Sunday service is provided during the holidays listed below and is subject to change.

- New Year's Day
- Memorial Day
- Independence Day
- Labor Day
- Thanksgiving Day
- Christmas Day



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Access observes the same holidays as Metro fixed route services. For current information on holiday service, visit Metro's Holiday Calendar at <http://www.go-metro.com>. Subscription Service (as explained in section 4) is automatically cancelled on Metro holidays. Passengers with subscription trips must call Access Reservations in advance of the holiday to avoid having a subscription trip automatically cancelled. Holidays that fall on a weekend but are observed on a Friday or a Monday will result in the cancellation of subscription trips on the observed holiday AND the actual holiday.

FARES

Access paratransit vehicle operators accept cash fares. Please have exact fare as the operator is unable to make change. Passengers are required to present either cash, a valid fare ticket or validated mobile ticket upon boarding a vehicle. Per the ADA, Access fares will not exceed twice the fare of the fixed route service.

Upon entering the Access vehicle, the passenger must provide ticket or cash fare for **each** trip. Passengers must also have their Access identification card with them while riding Access.

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FARE TICKET	\$4
Fare tickets must be presented to the driver with Access ID when boarding. Not valid on Metro buses.	GOOD FOR ACCESS FARE ONLY

ACCESS 

Access passengers must provide the appropriate fare to receive service. This is consistent with passengers riding Metro's fixed route bus system. Companions are required to pay the same fare as the ADA paratransit eligible individuals they accompany, unless the companion is five (5) years of age or younger. Companions performing the duties of a personal care attendant will not be charged for paratransit service.

Using, producing, or distributing fraudulent fare media as well as using other passengers' passes are grounds for service suspension, and may result in service termination and possible prosecution.

Access Operators are not allowed to accept tips and/or gifts for services.



PURCHASING ACCESS TICKETS

- By mail or in person:
 - Metro's Sales Office
Mercantile Center Ste. 1
120 E 4th Street
Cincinnati, Ohio 45202
 - Silverton Assessment Center
7000 Montgomery Road
Cincinnati, Ohio 45236
- By Phone:
 - 513-632-7669
 - 513-632-7540

Section 4: Access Trip Reservations

As soon as a passenger is determined eligible for Access Paratransit service, they may start using the service. The first step is to make a reservation (or book a trip) for a ride. Eligibility belongs to the passenger and therefore only the passenger or the authorized care giver may make reservations. Anyone other than the passenger or the authorized care giver wants to make trip reservations on behalf of a rider, Access agent may ask title and name of person making the reservation on behalf of the passenger.



Passengers are reminded that Access is a shared ride service that provides comparable ride times to those of Metro's fixed route services. Ride times are not comparable to those of a taxi or a private vehicle. Please keep this in mind when making a reservation and allow ample time for travel to and from the destination.

Access utilizes a mixed fleet of vehicles to provide paratransit service. Individual vehicle requirements are determined during the eligibility process and may not be requested at the time of reservation. Requests for a specific vehicle operator or service provider will not be accommodated.

BEFORE MAKING A RESERVATION

Prior to making a reservation, passengers should gather the following information about their trips:

- Passenger name and Access I.D. number.
- Complete street addresses of pick up and drop off locations (for example, 1234 Main Street, suite 102).
- Date(s) and time(s) of travel.
- Appointment time or any other time constraint (if applicable).
- Information about any individuals who will be traveling with the passenger.
- Information about any mobility devices the passenger will be using.

- Additional information about the pick-up and drop off locations (business name, building number, gate code, apartment complex name, office building, grocery store, etc.).
- Any other information that will help the vehicle operator locate the passenger.

Access is a shared ride service so please keep this in mind by allowing extra travel time between trips.

MAKING A RESERVATION

Registered Access passengers may make a reservation (book a trip) through the Customer Care Center (live agent).

Trips will be scheduled with a window of time called the 30-minute window. This 30-minute window will be the timeframe during which a passenger can expect the pick-up to occur.

Registered Access passengers may call directly into the Customer Care Center and speak with a live agent to schedule a ride, cancel a ride, and/or receive other assistance regarding their Access service. The customer may book a reservation up to seven (7) days in advance. The steps for contacting a live agent to schedule or cancel a ride include:

1. Call (513) 531-8888.
2. The agent will come on the line and walk the caller through the process.
3. Before hanging up, the agent will confirm the trip reservation and repeat the travel information.
4. The agent will also help determine the best location to wait for the ride.



SUBSCRIPTION TRIPS

If passengers travel to the same location at least once a week for 90 days (on the same day and at the same time) they may be eligible to receive subscription service. If they are eligible and approved, this service will provide passengers with a standing reservation for their trip. Subscription trips may help to increase the consistency of a passenger's schedule but it will not be a guarantee of an exact ride time, a regular vehicle operator, or a specific vehicle type.

Subscriptions are automatically cancelled on Metro holidays. Passengers who still need their rides on a Metro holiday must call

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no later than 5pm the day before service to retain their subscription trip.

Current subscription trips will be permanently cancelled in cases where a passenger faces service suspension due to service disruption or in cases where a passenger has excessive no-shows or late cancellations. These passengers will need to reapply for new subscription service if they feel it is still needed at a later point.

Subscription ride services may not always be available when a request is submitted. Requests will be kept on file for up to three months and may be fulfilled as space becomes available.

Passengers with subscription trips have the option to temporarily place subscription rides on hold for a maximum period of 30 days. Passengers who leave their subscription on hold for longer than 30 days will lose their subscription.

Any changes needed in a subscription schedule (for example, time change, address changes, etc.) may result in the loss of the subscription due to that change. The resulting schedule “slot” will then be made available to other passengers.



ATTENDANTS, COMPANIONS AND CHILDREN

Each registered Access passenger may ride with

- One (1) personal care attendant (PCA) who provides individual assistance to the Access passenger. Attendants are limited to one (1) per passenger and will not be charged for the trip. Attendants must board and exit the vehicle at the same time and location as the passengers they are assisting.
- One (1) companion. Additional companions may also travel with the passenger on a space available basis. Each companion must pay the same rate as the registered Access passenger.

Companions must board and exit the vehicle at the same time and location as the passengers they are accompanying.

Children of a registered Access passenger may ride with the passenger as a companion. Additional children will be accommodated on a space available basis. Reservations for all riders must be made in advance and children six (6) years of age or older must also pay the same fare as the Access passenger. Children five (5) years of age or younger who are registered Access passengers must pay the Access fare and must be accompanied by an adult.

Access passengers traveling with a child or children under the age of eight (8) years old and shorter than 57 inches are encouraged



to provide and secure a child safety seat for each child matching these criteria. This is not required and is therefore not a basis for denying a trip. Access will not provide child safety seats for any passengers. The passenger is solely responsible to ensure the seat is safe and can be secured safely.

CANCELLING TRIPS

Cancellations are a large source of system inefficiency for this valuable community resource. Please cancel trips with as much advance notice as possible so that rides can be made available to other Access passengers. Passengers may cancel trips by speaking to a live agent. Passengers who need to cancel a trip on the day of service must do so at least one (1) to two (2) hours prior to the beginning of the 30-minute window to avoid a late cancellation penalty. Late cancellation penalties are equivalent to no-shows and are outlined in detail under the no-show section of this guide in section 7.

CHANGING TRIPS

Previously scheduled trips may be changed at any time without penalty up to 5 p.m. on the day before service. Changes of location or time on a previously scheduled trip after 6 p.m. may not be honored. The Access vehicle operators are not authorized to make trip changes for any current or future trips.

Section 5: Taking an Access Trip

PICK-UP AND DROP-OFF TIMES

Access schedules rides using a 30-minute window for passenger pick-ups. Passengers should be ready to board the vehicle 15 minutes before or after their scheduled trip time. Passengers must be ready to board the vehicle within five (5) minutes after the vehicle arrives, but passengers may board early. Failure to board the vehicle within five minutes may result in a no-show occurrence. Passengers are **not** required to board a vehicle if it arrives before the 30-minute window begins, and the 5-minute period to board the vehicle does not start until the beginning of the designated 30-minute window. Passengers who have not been picked up after the 30-minute window has expired are encouraged to call the ETA line at (513) 531-6888, extension 1.



PICK-UP AND DROP-OFF LOCATIONS

Access operators are only authorized to pick-up or drop-off passengers at the location for which the ride was scheduled. Passengers must wait for their ride at the agreed upon location or risk being counted for a no-show. Access operators are not permitted to lose sight of the vehicle or use stairs beyond the first-floor entry of a building when assisting a passenger. Access does not allow operators to enter a passenger's home or lock/unlock the door.

DESIGNATED BOARDING AREAS

Large facilities such as hospitals, malls, or office buildings may have predetermined Access passenger pick-up and drop-off designated areas. The designated area will be explained to passengers at the time they make a reservation for one of these large facilities. These facilities are routinely evaluated for maximum safety and accessibility and are the only authorized designated areas at these facilities. Consistent designated areas allow passengers to have a dependable, safe, comfortable, and efficient place to wait for their Access rides.



UNSAFE LOCATIONS

Some locations within the service area present a significant safety risk to passengers, operators, vehicles, or property. In these rare cases Access might not be able to provide services beyond curb-to-curb; however, Access will work with the passengers to find safe alternatives that will allow service to remain accessible to everyone. This may include designating a location as curb-to-curb only.

Each of these locations will be assessed individually and in person by a member of the Access staff. Standardized evaluation criteria will be used to evaluate each location in question. Affected passengers are encouraged to be involved in the location review if possible.

TIPS FOR OTHER PICK-UP LOCATIONS

Not all locations are the same, so Access has created a simple list to help determine the best place to wait for a ride when there is not a predetermined Access boarding area:

- Passengers living in a single-family home need to wait at the front door.



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- Passengers living in an apartment complex need to wait at a location where the vehicle operator can find them.
- Passengers in an office building (high rise, hospital, etc.) need to wait on the ground level at the main entrance.
- Passengers in a building such as a hospital where there are two sets of doors (a foyer) need to wait in an area where the paratransit vehicle operator can see them.
- Passengers in a location that is not accessible to the vehicle operator need to wait outside. Passengers should remain as close to the entrance as possible.

BOARDING THE VEHICLE

Upon the arrival of the Access vehicle passengers must show their ID card, pay the fare, and board the vehicle. The Operator will assist with mobility device (wheelchair, walker, etc.) securement and the passenger seat belt.

Reminder: Access Paratransit is a shared ride service. Other passengers may be in the vehicle when a passenger gets in and may be dropped off or picked up while enroute to the passenger's destination.

USING THE LIFT

The vehicles in the Access fleet are equipped with a lift to assist passengers into and out of the vehicle. Access vehicles can secure wheelchairs and other mobility aids in the rear of the vehicle. Vehicle lifts are not limited only to those people who use mobility devices, so if a passenger would like to board the vehicle using the lift, he or she must let the Access operator know.

Please follow these simple safety steps when using the lift:

- Power off any electric mobility device before the lift moves
- Lock the wheels of any mobility device equipped with brakes
- Standing passengers should hold both railings if able to do so
- Access operators are not authorized to ride with passengers on the lift



TRANSPORTING PASSENGER ITEMS

Access operators are primarily responsible for the safety of the passenger. Access operators are not allowed to carry any items. It is the responsibility of the passenger to transport items to and from the vehicle without the assistance of the operator. Passengers must be able to maintain control of all packages or see that they have been secured properly while on the vehicle during transport. Passengers should expect to hold their packages on their laps during travel to allow room for others while on board.

Passengers needing additional assistance are encouraged to bring a PCA (personal care attendant) or a companion for these trips. Any large, oversized items (i.e., large boxes, shopping carts, etc.) that cannot be held by the passenger or properly secured will not be transported.

It is recommended that all bags, luggage, large boxes etc. have handles for the customer to hold. The carrying of packages by the passenger between the passenger origin/destination and the vehicle must be done in one trip. The passenger is not permitted to make multiple trips to or from the vehicle.

Access will not be responsible for broken, damaged, spoiled, lost or stolen items.

REACHING THE DESTINATION

When the passenger has reached his or her destination, remain seated until the vehicle comes to a complete stop and the vehicle operator has indicated it is safe to prepare to exit the vehicle. The Access Operator will help the passenger from the vehicle.

MOBILITY DEVICES

Access vehicles can safely accommodate a wide range of mobility devices. Mobility devices are noted on all passenger accounts, and passengers should always update the Eligibility Department when there is a change and/or addition of a mobility device. This allows Access to send the appropriate vehicle type for the trip as well as reserve enough space on board for passengers and their mobility devices.

- Access will guarantee transportation for passengers with wheelchairs. The definition of “wheelchair” is defined as:
 - A “three- or **more** wheeled device”

Wheelchairs that fall outside of these guidelines might still be accommodated but will be evaluated on an individualized basis to see if



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Access vehicles and lifts will be able to physically transport them safely.

Access vehicles are unable to accommodate or safely transport chairs that are lightweight, transporter chairs. Transporter wheelchairs are not manufactured or constructed for securement inside a moving vehicle. Passengers are permitted to use a transport wheelchair to board the vehicle but must be able to transfer to a seat in order to be transported.

Other equipment that is not permitted on any Access vehicle includes, but is not limited to: hospital beds, stretchers, Hoyer lifts, large shopping carts, or any other device that poses a safety risk. Devices that are not in proper working order (failing brakes, flat tires, etc.), or that are unsanitary may not be transported.

Mobility devices must be secured every time they ride on an

Access vehicle.

Operators are responsible for ensuring that mobility devices are properly secured. Access always requires the use of a lap belt or seatbelt



ACCESS 

during transport. Access recommends but does not require the use of a shoulder harness for passengers traveling in a mobility device.

Access passengers who acquire a new or larger type of mobility device must notify the Access Eligibility Department before making a reservation or taking a trip with the new mobility device.

SERVICE ANIMALS

Service animals are defined as any guide dog, signal dog or other animal individually trained to perform tasks directly related to



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assisting an individual with a disability. Animals that are not individually trained to perform such tasks, including animals used purely for emotional purposes, are not considered service animals. When scheduling a trip, passengers should inform the Access reservation agent that they will be traveling with a service animal.

PASSENGER ATTENDANT/AIDE REQUIREMENTS

Passengers will be required to travel with an attendant or aide under the following conditions:

- Passengers five (5) years of age or younger.
- Professional determination that a passenger should always have an attendant/aide because he or she poses a danger to herself/himself.
- Passengers identified by Access transportation professionals as requiring an attendant/aide for safety reasons.
- Passengers with temporary or unexpected occasional need for assistance that cannot be met by the Access vehicle operator.
- Passengers who cannot be left unattended or who qualify for hand-to-hand service and are traveling to a drop-off location where no one will be present to receive them.

Passengers who will need to travel with a personal care attendant or aide will need to have this information documented with Access during the eligibility determination process.



Section 6: Vehicle Operator Responsibilities

Passengers can expect the operator to:

- Operate the vehicle safely under all circumstances.
- Wear the proper uniform.
- Get out of the vehicle and announce his or her arrival, except when it is curb-to-curb and/or not at ground level.
- Verify the identity of the passenger being transported.
- Offer assistance to the passenger by pushing a wheelchair or offering an arm for guidance.
- Collect the proper fare before assisting passengers into the vehicle.
- Operate the lift: safety is the top priority.
- Transport the passenger only to the pre-scheduled location unless directed otherwise from a supervisor or dispatch.
- Assist passengers to their destination.

Operators are prohibited from:

- Entering past the front entrance of a public building.
- Entering a passenger's residence.
- Leaving passengers unattended in a vehicle.

- Losing sight of their vehicle.
- Manually lifting or carrying passengers.
- Taking trip reservations or cancellations from a passenger.
- Using a personal cell phone while operating a vehicle or providing passenger assistance.
- Accepting monetary tips or gifts.

Section 7: Access Passenger Policies

DISRUPTIVE BEHAVIOR & RULE VIOLATIONS

Service disruptions, rule violations, or dangerous behavior while traveling on an Access vehicle may result in suspension of paratransit service. When a rule violation occurs, Access shall make every effort to work toward resolution by identifying the problem and, if appropriate, working with the passenger to find an alternative solution to suspension.

NO-SHOW AND LATE CANCELLATION POLICY

Passengers that frequently fail to properly cancel a trip or do not show up in time for their scheduled ride will be subject to a progressive penalty that may lead to service suspension. The following actions are considered no-show occurrences for the purpose of this policy:

- 
- When a vehicle arrives for a passenger inside the trip window and the passenger does not board the vehicle within five (5) minutes.
 - When a passenger refuses a scheduled trip at the door.
 - Late cancellations that occur one (1) to two (2) hours from the scheduled trip time (also known as a Late Cancel).

NO-SHOW SUSPENSION

The Access suspension policy takes effect when a passenger has excessive no-shows in 28-day period. Excessive no-shows are identified as 10% or more of scheduled trips in a continuous 28-day period.

- Excessive no-shows will result in a 1-week suspension.
- Excessive no-shows following a 1-week suspension within the same calendar year will result in subsequent suspensions:
 - Second suspension will be two (2) weeks (14 days.)
 - Third suspension will be three (3) weeks (21 days.)
 - Fourth and subsequent suspensions will be four (4) weeks (28 days.)

Trips missed by the individual for reasons beyond their control shall not be a basis for determining that such a pattern or practice exists.



Prior to service suspension Access administrative staff will review all no-shows and late cancellations to ensure that the administrative process was followed properly and an accurate count is represented. No shows and late cancellations that are found to be in error will be removed from the customer's record. All no-shows and late cancellations drop from the customer's record after 28 consecutive days.

NO-SHOW PASSENGER SUSPENSION NOTIFICATION

Suspension notification letters will be sent to all passengers in violation of the policy. Each letter will clearly identify the dates of each violation from the previous month as well as the dates when the passenger's service will be suspended. All appeals related to the no-show policy will be reviewed through the appeals process as outlined in this guide.

Section 8: Service Suspension Appeal Procedures

Before suspension or termination may take place, Access must notify the passenger by USPS or electronic mail of the intention to suspend service. This notification shall inform the passenger of the reason(s) for the proposed suspension and shall state that the passenger has a right to appeal.



The passenger may call or write the Eligibility Administrator at (513) 632-7586 to request a suspension appeal hearing within five (5) working days or send notice at the following address:

Access
1801 Transpark Drive
Cincinnati, OH 45229

If the passenger does **not** request a suspension appeal hearing within five (5) working days, service will be suspended/terminated on the 6th day. The passenger will be notified by certified mail of the suspension/termination and the effective day of the suspension/termination.

Should the passenger request a suspension appeal hearing concerning the suspension or termination of existing service, an appeal committee, consisting of a three (3) person panel of individuals not involved in the original decision, will be formed. This appeal procedure is unrelated to eligibility and will not to be used for contesting established Metro policies.

The appeal committee will:

- Conduct a hearing within 30 working days of the passenger's request to affirm or rescind the suspension/termination decision;

- Only meet to address suspension/termination of service;
- Affirm or rescind the decision within the 30 working days after the hearing.

Service will continue until the committee renders its decision. The decision of the appeals committee is final.

Section 9: Passenger Service Questions, Comments and Complaints

Access wants to hear what you have to say. For commendations for Access staff members, concerns about the service, complaints, frequent questions or suggestions please contact the Customer Care Center:

- Phone: (513) 632-7575
- E-mail: CustomerService@go-metro.com
- Mail: Customer Care Center
1801 Transpark Drive
Cincinnati, OH 45229

TITLE VI

Any person who believes that he or she, individually, or as a member of any specific class of persons, has been subjected to discrimination



on the basis of race, color, or national origin as noted below may file a written complaint with the SORTA's Title VI Coordinator at 525 Vine St, Suite 500, Cincinnati, Ohio, 45202. Complainants have the right to complain directly to the appropriate federal agency. Every effort will be made to obtain early resolution of complaints. The option of informal meeting(s) between the affected parties and the Title VI Coordinator may be utilized for resolutions. The Title VI Coordinator will notify SORTA's General Manager/CEO of all Title VI related complaints as well as all resolutions.

This procedure does not preclude the right of any Complainant to file complaints directly with the Federal Transportation Administration (FTA), or to seek private legal representation. The time required to process investigations will vary depending on the complexity of the issue; however, every effort will be made to ensure a speedy resolution of all complaints at the lowest possible level within 90 business days. The option of informal mediation meeting(s) between the affected parties may be utilized for resolution.

For more information please visit <https://www.go-metro.com/how-to-ride/howtoride/accessibility1/accessibility2/title-vi>

REASONABLE MODIFICATION

To ensure that programs and services are accessible to customers with a disability, an individual may request that a modification to Access' public transit services be made to allow them to access and utilize the services.

There are no restrictions on when a customer can request a reasonable modification although the Access supports and encourages customers to place a written request as soon as possible.

EXCEPTIONS

Reasonable modification requests to Access and Metro Staff must consider any and all requests for reasonable modifications but shall take into account the following exceptions:

Reasonable modifications:

- Will not place an undue financial and/or administrative burden on the Access or Metro;
- Will not constitute a fundamental alteration of Access' current transportation services, programs or activities;
- Cannot cause a direct threat to the health or safety of others;
- Cannot adversely affect the service provided to other Access or Metro customers;

- Cannot jeopardize the functionality or use of equipment used to provide Access or Metro transit services; and
- May not be approved if the individual with a disability is still able to fully use Access or Metro's services, programs, or activities for their intended purpose without the requested modification.

For more information or to request a reasonable modification, please visit <https://www.go-metro.com/access>

Section 10: Glossary

30-minute Window: The period when a passenger can expect to be picked up. Passengers must be ready to board the vehicle within 5 minutes after the vehicle arrives.

Actual Vehicle Arrival Time: The time that the vehicle arrives at the ride origin and is ready to be boarded.

Actual Vehicle Departure Time: The time that the vehicle departs the ride origin.

Actual Vehicle Drop-Off Time: The time that the vehicle arrives at the ride destination and is ready for deboarding.

ADA: The Americans with Disabilities Act of 1990.

ADA Paratransit Eligible: The status given to a person who has been determined to be eligible to use Access Transportation under the ADA Paratransit Program.

Attendant: May also referred to as a Personal Care Attendant (PCA). A person traveling as an aide, such as a personal care attendant, requested by a person with a disability to facilitate travel and having the same origin and destination as the person with a disability.

Companion: A person (who may or may not be registered with Access) other than a PCA traveling with an ADA eligible passenger and having the same origins and destinations as the eligible person.

Conditional Eligibility: When an ADA eligible person can use fixed route unless certain conditions are present that prevent them from getting to or from or navigating fixed route service.





Curb-to-curb: Vehicle operators assist passenger into and out of the vehicle only. Operators must not leave the direct vicinity of the vehicle and are not required to provide assistance beyond the curb of the origin or destination.

Demand Trips: Eligible riders who call in ride requests for non-routine rides at least one (1) day and up to seven (7) days in advance of the desired ride.

Destination: The location where a rider de-boards a vehicle at the completion of a ride.

Dispatching: The act of issuing instructions and receiving communications to and from vehicle operators via radio contact and electronic manifests.

Door-to-door: Vehicle operators assist passengers to the door of the origin and to the door of the destination but are not permitted to cross the threshold of either location.

Driver: An individual operating a vehicle to transport riders and any attendants and companions. Used interchangeably with “vehicle operator”.

Eligibility Evaluation Trip:

Trips that are provided free of charge upon request by the applicant to and from an appointment where Eligibility staff will determine eligibility for ADA transportation.



Eligible Rider: A person registered with Metro as eligible to use Access.

Fare: The determined cost to the rider for a ride on any mode of Transportation provided by Metro or Access.

Fixed Route Services:

Bus service operated or subcontracted by a transit agency in which a vehicle is operated along a prescribed route according to a fixed schedule.



Individual Subscription Ride: A ride in which a single individual goes between the same origin and destination a minimum of three (3) times per week.

Manifest: Written record of information required for the vehicle operator's transportation delivery and drop-off instructions, including scheduled and actual times.

Access: Metro's paratransit transportation service operated under the policies set forth in Metro's ADA Paratransit Service Plan.

Access ID number: The unique passenger number assigned by Metro and appearing on the Access photo ID card.

On Time: Within fifteen (15) minutes before to fifteen (15) minutes after the scheduled time of the trip.

Origin: The location where a rider boards a vehicle at the beginning of a ride.

Personal Care Attendant (PCA): A person designated specifically to help an individual with a disability meet his or her personal needs.

Registered Passenger: A person registered with Metro as eligible to use Access.



Reservation Agent: May also be referred to as a Care Center Agent. An individual who responds to requests for transportation and informs a rider of the disposition of the ride request.

Return Trip: Second leg of a round trip.

Round Trip: When a passenger returns to the point of origin from a single destination within the same day (counted as two trips).

Scheduled Pick-up Time: Time that serves as the middle of the 30-minute window (15 minutes before and after the scheduled time).

Service Animals: Any animal that a passenger identifies as a trained animal and is needed by the rider or their personal care attendant or companion to help with daily activities.

Shared Ride Service: Transportation service where multiple passengers may be transported at the same times on the same vehicle with varied ride times and non-sequential pick-ups and drop-offs.

Vehicle Operator:

Synonymous with Driver. Employees who operate vehicles transporting passengers.

Section 11: Contact Information & Fares

TELEPHONE LISTINGS

Access

Reservations	(513) 531-8888
ETA Line	(513) 531-6888, ext. 1
Customer service	(513) 632-7575
Eligibility/appeals & General Information	(513) 632-7586
TTY for hearing impaired: Ohio Relay Service	1-800-750-0750

FARES *(Effective April 4, 2021)*

Access fare is \$4 for each trip and must be presented at the time of boarding.

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